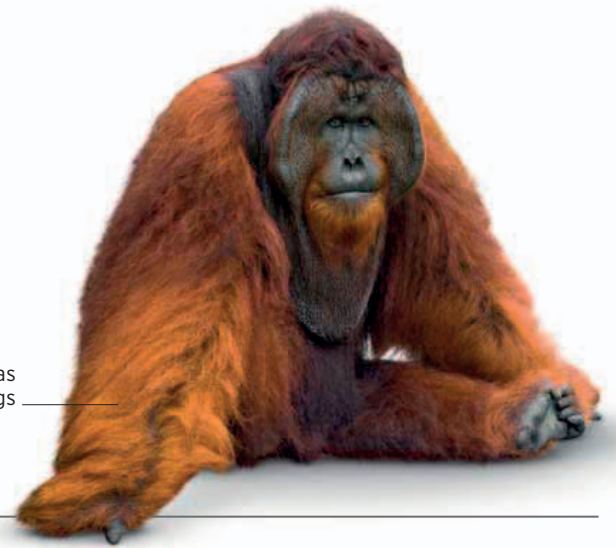


Bornean orangutan

Pongo pygmaeus

arms twice as
long as legs



The orangutan is the only great ape to live in Asia. Its name means “man of the forest” in Malay. This shaggy, red-haired ape is found in the forests of Borneo and Sumatra. The Bornean species outnumbers the Sumatran orangutan (*P. abelii*) by almost 10 to one. However, with a population of around 55,000, Bornean orangutans are still highly endangered.

Life in the trees

Orangutans spend the day climbing up branches in search of food and sleep in trees at night. Their arm span is considerably longer than their height—an adult male’s arms can span around 7 ft (2.2 m)—so they can reach for branches and swing across precipitous drops with relative ease. Weighing about the same as an adult human, although six times stronger, orangutans cannot reach the very top of trees safely and so spend most of their time in the lower 130 ft (40 m) of the forest. Older males are too heavy to climb that high, and in Borneo, where there are no large predators to

speak of, the males spend long periods on the ground. Females and younger males, by contrast, may not touch the ground for weeks on end.

Orangutans feed primarily on fruit, using their dextrous hands and their teeth to remove the peel and expose the flesh. They also eat leaves, bark, and flowers, as well as honey, birds’ eggs, insects, and fish.

Solitary ape

Adult male orangutans stay out of each other’s way, using a series of calls to advertise their presence and warn off neighbors. Some male Bornean orangutans do not develop facial flaps when mature. They are less vocal and use stealth tactics to approach and mate with a female while the other males are vying with each other for mating rights. Female orangutans may spend short periods feeding in small groups, letting their young play together. A female orangutan cares for her young for about seven years, and will not have another until the previous offspring has become independent.

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.1–1.4 m)
- ⚖ 88–176 lb (40–80 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🍌 Plants, eggs, insects
- 🏠



SE. Asia (Borneo)

◁ MATURE MALE

There is considerable physical difference between male and female orangs. Most males develop wide facial flaps at the age of 14, and grow a thin moustache and beard.



△ NIGHT NEST

Orangutans sleep in nests made of folded branches. They make a fresh one every night.

◁ A SIP OF RAIN

A young orangutan drinks rainwater dripping from forest leaves. Orangutans often use a leafy branch as an umbrella in heavy downpours.